Biography

H 1330

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A. Background

A work about an individual person may be either biographical, critical, or both. Biographical works focus on the personal aspects of the individual's life, critical works on the individual's

professional, intellectual, or artistic achievements. The provisions in this instruction sheet do not apply to works that are predominantly critical, only to works that are predominantly biographical and in narrative form.

LC practice: As stated in H 1075, LC catalogers will no longer use form subdivisions. Instead assign an appropriate term or terms from Library of Congress Genre/Form Terms (LCGFT), e.g. ***Biographies***. To replace a form subdivision that includes a demographic group, also assign Library of Congress Demographic Groups Terms (LCDGT) to bring out the audience of the resource being cataloged, e.g. ***German speakers*** or ***Arabic, Students of***.

For guidelines on bio-bibliography, see H 1328. For guidelines on diaries, see H 1538. For guidelines on interviews, see H 1678. For guidelines on personal narratives of wars or disasters, see H 1928. For guidelines on genealogy and family histories, see H 1631. For classification of biography, see F 275 (General); F 605, sec. 1 (Government officials); and F 632 (Literary authors writing in more than one language).

B. Recent revisions

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.

C. Definitions

Biography (including Autobiography): A narrative work more than 50% of which recounts the personal aspects of the life of one or more individuals. (In the case of historical figures, particularly those from the distant past, where little is known of the personal details of their lives, the limitation of the definition to "personal aspects" does not apply.) Personal aspects include such details as the individual's early years, education, marriage and other personal relationships, personal habits and personality, family life, travels, personal experiences and tragedies, last years and death, etc. Life means a relatively large portion of the individual's life, not just a single brief incident.

Collective biography: A biography of two or more individuals.

Individual biography: A biography of one person.

Partial biography: A work that includes some, but less than 50%, biographical material.

D. General rule

Assign an appropriate combination of the following types of headings to a biography:

- the name heading(s) for the person(s) [no more than four]
- if appropriate, a "class of persons" heading with the free-floating form subdivision ***--Biography***

- if appropriate, heading(s) to bring out the person's association with a place or organization, or involvement with a specific event
- topical headings, as appropriate for the work

Each of these headings is discussed specifically in sections D.1-D.4 below.

LC practice: Assign an appropriate combination of subject heading(s) for a biography. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Biographies*** or the more specific term.

D.1. Name heading for the person

Assign the heading as established in RDA form in the name authority file. Do not subdivide the name by ***--Biography***.

If the biography focuses on a specific aspect of the person's life subdivide the name heading using the appropriate topical subdivision from H 1110, for example, ***--Childhood and youth***, ***--Health***, ***--Death and burial***. Assign this heading as the first heading.

Note Exception: ***--Biography*** has been established and may be used under the names of four individuals: ***Shakespeare, William, 1564-1616***; ***Muhammad, Prophet, -632***; ***Jesus Christ***; and ***Mary, Blessed Virgin, Saint***. Do not submit a proposal to establish ***--Biography*** under the name of any other individual.

LC practice: For the four names that are editorially established with the ***--Biography*** subdivision, use instead the name only. The existing subject authority records for those four names will continue to exist in order to accommodate existing practice for external institutions. Instead assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Biographies*** or the more specific term.

D.1.a. Literary authors

For literary authors who write under various names and have more than one name heading, use the heading that serves as the "base heading" for the author, that is, the heading having the complete set of references for the author. Free-floating use of the subdivision ***--Biography*** after headings for individual literary authors was discontinued in 1998. The subdivision is established under ***Shakespeare, William, 1564-1616***, and continues to be used under that heading as an exceptional practice.

LC practice: Note exception above for LC practice for the four editorially established names.

D.1.b. Official name heading vs. personal name heading

For individuals who have both an official name heading and a personal name heading, use the personal name heading. For example, use ***Reagan, Ronald*** rather than ***United States. President (1981-1989 : Reagan)***.

D.1.c. Collective biography

If the work is about two, three, or four persons, assign the name heading for each. If the work is about more than four persons, omit the name headings.

D.2. [Class of persons]--Biography

This heading designates the group of people to which the biographee belongs, as discussed in the work being cataloged, for example, ***Musicians***, ***Heads of state***, ***Football coaches***, ***Italy--Kings and rulers***, etc.

LC practice: Assign the subject term for the class of persons. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Biographies*** or the more specific term.

Note: This heading is assigned to individual biographies primarily for the benefit of public library users who are seeking biographies of a particular type of person rather than a particular individual. The heading should be selected with that in mind. If the biographee belongs to no discernible class of persons of the type judged likely to be sought by the typical public library user, it may be omitted.

D.2.a. Persons with multifaceted lives or careers

For a biography that discusses the entire life of a person, select the single heading that best encompasses his or her career or lifelong pursuits. In order to achieve consistency, check the bibliographic database first to determine the heading that has been used on other biographies of the same person. If a single heading cannot adequately encompass the person's career or lifelong pursuits, assign more than one heading, provided that the work being cataloged discusses the various aspects of the person's life designated by the headings assigned. If the work focuses on only one facet, assign only that one heading. For example, if a work discusses Albert Schweitzer’s experiences only as a medical missionary, assign a heading for only that aspect of his career.

D.2.b. Headings qualified by sex or ethnic group

Assign headings that specify the sex or ethnic group of the class of persons, such as ***Women architects***, ***African American lawyers***, etc., if that is a significant aspect of the work. When assigning this heading, assign it in addition to the unqualified heading for the class of persons.

Example:

Title: "Just make them beautiful" : the many worlds of a designing woman / by Helen Rose.

600 10 $a Rose, Helen, $d 1904-1985.

650 #0 $a Costume designers $z California $z Los Angeles $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Women costume designers $z California $z Los Angeles $v Biography.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Rose, Helen, $d 1904-1985.

650 #0 $a Costume designers $z California $z Los Angeles.

650 #0 $a Women costume designers $z California $z Los Angeles.

655 #7 $a Biographies. $2 lcgft

Title: Black in Selma : the uncommon life of J.L. Chestnut, Jr.

600 10 $a Chestnut, J. L.

650 #0 $a Lawyers $z Alabama $v Biography.

650 #0 $a African American lawyers $z Alabama $v Biography.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Chestnut, J. L.

650 #0 $a Lawyers $z Alabama.

650 #0 $a African American lawyers $z Alabama.

655 #7 $a Biographies. $2 lcgft

D.2.c. Collective biography with no class of persons

If a collective biography encompasses a group of people for which a heading representing a class of persons does not exist and cannot be formulated, establish the subdivision ***--Biography*** under the appropriate topical heading. For example, establish ***Art--Biography*** for a collective biography of artists, dealers, collectors, museum personnel, etc.

LC practice: Assign the subject heading for the topic when a class of persons does not exist and cannot be formulated. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Biographies*** or the more specific term.

D.3. Headings for place, organization, or event

Assign headings of this type, with the subdivision ***--Biography***, in addition to the class of persons heading described above, if that is a significant aspect of the work.

LC practice: Assign the subject heading for the place, organization, or event. Also assign LCGFT appropriate to the form and/or genre of the resource in hand, e.g. LCGFT ***Biographies*** or the more specific term.

Example:

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651 #0 $a Ohio $v Biography.
610 10 $a United States. $b Department of Agriculture $x Officials and
       employees $v Biography.
650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945 $v Biography.
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LC practice:

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651 #0 $a Ohio.
610 10 $a United States. $b Department of Agriculture $x Officials and
       employees.
650 #0 $a World War, 1939-1945.
655 #7 $a Biographies. $2 lcgft
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D.4. Topical headings

Assign headings for other topics discussed in the work, using appropriate subject headings without biographical subdivisions.

E. Special situations

E.1. Founders of major religions

Assign no heading to designate the class of persons.

E.2. Animals and pets

See H 1720, sec. 3.

E.3. Spouses of famous people

For a biographical work about a famous person's spouse who is or was active in a particular field, assign the heading for the class of persons that designates the spouse's own field. If the spouse has no special career of his or her own, and the work describes personal experiences as the spouse of a more famous person and his or her career, assign the heading for the specific category of spouses, for example, ***Ambassadors' spouses***, ***Entertainers' spouses***, etc., as the "class of persons" heading. If appropriate, also assign headings for the name of the more famous person and the class of persons to which he or she belongs.

E.4. Immigrants

See H 1581, sec. 3.c.

F. Partial biography

To works about an individual person that are less than 50% biographical, assign only the name of the person, subdivided if appropriate by subdivisions listed in H 1110, and the appropriate topical headings. Do not assign headings to designate the class of persons, or the individual's sex, ethnic group, association with a place, organization, etc. Examples of this type of work are critical works about individual artists, literary authors, philosophers, theologians, etc., as well as works about the life and times of individual statesmen or rulers in which there is more about the history of the time than the life of the ruler.

G. Extended examples

Title: Voices of America

[collection of veterans tell their personal accounts of military service]

610 20 $a Texas Christian University $x Alumni and alumnae $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Veterans $z United States $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Families of military personnel $z United States $v Biography.

651 #0 $a United States $x Armed Forces $v Biography.

651 #0 $a United States $x Armed Forces $x Military life.

LC practice:

610 20 $a Texas Christian University $x Alumni and alumnae.

650 #0 $a Veterans $z United States.

650 #0 $a Families of military personnel $z United States.

651 #0 $a United States $x Armed Forces.

651 #0 $a United States $x Armed Forces $x Military life.

655 #7 $a Autobiographies. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Personal narratives. $2 lcgft

Title: "Big Cy" and other characters : Pat MacAdam's Cape Breton

[collection of stories about people from Cape Breton Island]

651 #0 $a Cape Breton Island (N.S.) $v Biography $v Anecdotes.

651 #0 $a Cape Breton Island (N.S.) $v Anecdotes.

LC practice:

651 #0 $a Cape Breton Island (N.S.)

655 #7 $a Biographies. $2 lcgft

655 #7 $a Anecdotes. $2 lcgft

Title: All things consoled : a daughter's memoir

[memoir of a daughter as she cares for her aging parents]

600 10 $a Hay, Elizabeth, $d 1951- $x Family.

650 #0 $a Adult children of aging parents $z Canada $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Caregivers $z Canada $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Dementia $x Patients $x Care.

650 #0 $a Aging parents $x Care.

650 #0 $a Authors, Canadian (English) $y 20th century $v Biography.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Hay, Elizabeth, $d 1951- $x Family.

650 #0 $a Adult children of aging parents $z Canada.

650 #0 $a Caregivers $z Canada.

650 #0 $a Dementia $x Patients $x Care.

650 #0 $a Aging parents $x Care.

650 #0 $a Authors, Canadian (English) $y 20th century.

655 #7 $a Autobographies. $2 lcgft

Title: Belinda : the political and private life of Belinda Stronach

[biography of Belinda Stronach as businesswoman and politician]

600 10 $a Stronach, Belinda.

610 10 $a Canada. $b Parliament. $b House of Commons $v Biography.

610 20 $a Liberal Party of Canada $v Biography.

610 20 $a Conservative Party of Canada $v Biography.

610 20 $a Magna International, Inc. $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Cabinet officers $z Canada $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Women cabinet officers $z Canada $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Women legislators $z Canada $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Legislators $z Canada $v Biography.

650 #0 $a Businesswomen $z Canada $v Biography.

LC practice:

600 10 $a Stronach, Belinda.

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610 10 $a Canada. $b Parliament. $b House of Commons.
610 20 $a Liberal Party of Canada.
610 20 $a Conservative Party of Canada.
610 20 $a Magna International, Inc.
650 #0 $a Cabinet officers $z Canada.
650 #0 $a Women cabinet officers $z Canada.
650 #0 $a Women legislators $z Canada.
650 #0 $a Legislators $z Canada.
650 #0 $a Businesswomen $z Canada.
655 #7 $a Biographies. $2 lcgft
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Revision history

2026-01: Updated template. Added instructions related to LCGFT implementation.